

Interview Transcripts: Algorithmic Amplification of Misinformation on Social Media

The Fake News

"Before we begin the interview questions, I am going to read you a news alert that has been widely circulating and shared on social media recently. Please listen carefully:

'There is an urgent warning tonight about a highly sophisticated new malware called GhostPic that is spreading rapidly across Instagram and Facebook. It appears as a simple photo message from a friend, but security experts are warning users not to open any image until the sender confirms they actually sent it. Once opened, the malware completely takes over the device, stealing all passwords, personal data, and identity information. Reports claim it has already affected over 15 million accounts in the last 24 hours, and national news networks are preparing special reports on the breach. The alert urges everyone to warn their contacts immediately, stating that this is not a drill.'

Now, keeping that piece of information in mind, I'd like to ask you a few questions about your social media habits."

Interview Responses

ARPITA AGRAWAL- Thinks the news is false

1. Can you tell me which social media platforms you use most often?

Honestly, it's a mix. TikTok is my go-to for entertainment and trends, I'm constantly scrolling. Then there's Instagram, that's where I keep up with friends and brands. And I'd say Twitter is for quick news or current events, even if it's chaotic.

2. How frequently do you rely on social media for news or important information?

I'd say a good portion of the time. I follow a lot of news outlets on Twitter, so that's where I get headlines first. Sometimes I'll see a news story breaking on TikTok even before the big networks cover it. It's faster.

3. Have you ever seen information online that you later realized was false? What was it about?

Oh yeah, absolutely. There was this post a few years back that a major celebrity had died in a car accident. It had a ton of shares and was even trending. It felt so real and emotional, and I think I might have even retweeted it to say 'so sad.' Then I found out a few hours later it was a total hoax.

4. What made you believe or trust that information initially?

Honestly, it was just the sheer volume of people posting about it. When everyone on my timeline is talking about the same thing, you just kind of assume it's true. Also, seeing a celebrity I follow 'reacting' to it adds a whole new level of 'realness'.

5. How did you eventually find out it was incorrect?

A few hours later, a friend of mine sent me a link to an official news site that was explicitly debunking the story, saying the celebrity's publicist had made a statement. I felt pretty dumb.

6. Did that misinformation affect your opinion or any decision you made?

For a moment, it did. It made me feel very sad and even led to a conversation with friends about how 'fragile' life is. I guess I shared it before thinking, so it affected what I was putting out to my network.

7. Have you ever shared something that later turned out to be false? What happened?

I think I have, with that celebrity death one. I remember feeling so embarrassed when I realized it was a hoax and immediately went back and deleted my retweet. I also felt like I'd let down the people who followed me for 'news'.

8. Do you feel social media shows you certain types of content more often? Why do you think that happens?

Oh, 100 percent. The 'For You' page on TikTok is uncanny. It knows my sense of humor better than I do. I think it's because it tracks everything I watch and like, so it just feeds me more of the same to keep me hooked.

9. Do you think posts with more likes, shares, or comments are more likely to appear in your feed?

For sure. If something is going viral and has a huge number of likes, I feel like it's almost guaranteed to pop up on my feed. The algorithm definitely prioritizes popularity over anything else.

10. What do you think is the biggest problem caused by misinformation online?

Honestly, I think it's how easily it can manipulate people. It can make us believe things that are totally false, from small things like a celebrity hoax to huge, important things like elections. It just creates so much confusion.

UDDISH MAINI- Thinks the news is true

1. Can you tell me which social media platforms you use most often?

I'm mostly on Whatsapp. That's how I stay in touch with family and my local community. Occasionally, I'll watch a cooking or car repair video on YouTube, but that's about it. It's too much otherwise.

2. How frequently do you rely on social media for news or important information?

Not very often, to be honest. I might see a link to a news story my friend shares, but I'll usually go to a traditional news channel, like my local evening news, to verify it first. I don't feel like social media is as reliable for hard facts.

3. Have you ever seen information online that you later realized was false? What was it about?

Yes, I have. During the last big health crisis, a family member shared this post about a natural remedy, some kind of tea that supposedly 'cured' the virus. At the time, everyone was so scared and looking for answers. I almost went out and bought the ingredients before my doctor set me straight.

4. What made you believe or trust that information initially?

Well, it came from a family member, someone I trust. And at the time, there was so much information coming out from official sources, and a lot of people were very skeptical of 'the system.' This natural remedy felt like a comforting, alternative solution.

5. How did you eventually find out it was incorrect?

It was actually during a check-up. I happened to mention it to my doctor, and he very gently told me that there was zero scientific evidence for it and that following such advice could actually be dangerous.

6. Did that misinformation affect your opinion or any decision you made?

It definitely made me feel more hopeful for a little while, but also more suspicious of other news. It has made me much, much more hesitant to believe any health advice that I see on social media now.

7. Have you ever shared something that later turned out to be false? What happened?

Not on a big platform, no. I'm too nervous about that. I might have sent it in a private message to my sister, and then later had to text her to say, 'Never mind, that wasn't true.' I wouldn't want to post it publicly and mislead people.

8. Do you feel social media shows you certain types of content more often? Why do you think that happens?

Yes, I do feel like I see a lot of a certain kind of political post or a specific type of 'get rich quick' ad. It seems like it must be looking at what I've clicked on in the past and trying to give me more of what it thinks I want.

9. Do you think posts with more likes, shares, or comments are more likely to appear in your feed?

Yes, I believe that's how it works. I often see posts at the top of my feed that have hundreds of likes and comments, even from people I don't know very well. It must be showing me what everyone else is finding interesting.

10. What do you think is the biggest problem caused by misinformation online?

For me, the biggest problem is that it can be genuinely dangerous. Look at the anti-vaccine stuff or the 'miracle cures.' It can cost people their health or even their lives, all because of a post that looked convincing.

MOHAMMAD ALI- Thinks the news is true

1. Can you tell me which social media platforms you use most often? I try not to spend too much time on social media. I mostly stick to Reddit, especially for specific hobbies since people actually have good conversations there. I'm on LinkedIn too for work stuff, but that's a totally different vibe.

2. How frequently do you rely on social media for news or important information? Almost never for actual facts. I mostly use it just to see how people are reacting to a story or to get different opinions. If I want to know what actually happened, I go straight to regular news websites or official sources.

3. Have you ever seen information online that you later realized was false? What was it about? Yeah, a few years ago I saw this post going around about a new law. It had a super professional-looking chart with all these economic stats. But when I actually looked up the original source, I realized they had totally twisted the numbers to make it look like something else. The numbers were real, but the way they set up the chart was completely misleading.

4. What made you believe or trust that information initially? Honestly, it just looked really well-made. It wasn't some messy, random post; it looked like a legit chart that made a complicated topic easy to understand. Plus, it was being shared by people in a group that I usually consider pretty smart, so I just assumed it was accurate.

5. How did you eventually find out it was incorrect? I'm kind of skeptical by nature, so I decided to check it myself. I spent like an hour trying to find the original government data the chart was talking about. It took some digging, but once I found the real numbers, it was super obvious that the post was a lie.

6. Did that misinformation affect your opinion or any decision you made? It didn't change my mind about the law, but it definitely made me lose trust in that specific online group. I realized they were just repeating whatever fit their views, and I couldn't rely on them for actual facts anymore, even if they seemed like smart people.

7. Have you ever shared something that later turned out to be false? What happened? I don't think I've ever shared something totally fake. I'm really careful about that. The closest I've come is maybe sharing an article that was super old without realizing it. But as soon as I noticed, I posted a comment saying, "Whoops, old news!" I try hard to make sure what I post is true.

8. Do you feel social media shows you certain types of content more often? Why do you think that happens? Oh, totally. That's just how these apps work. They track everything you do—what you click, how long you watch a video, even what you hover over. They don't care if a post is true; they just care if it keeps you scrolling. So they show you stuff that makes you angry or excited because that's what keeps you on the app longer.

9. Do you think posts with more likes, shares, or comments are more likely to appear in your feed? Definitely. If a post gets a lot of likes and comments, the app thinks it's a "good" post and shows it to even more people. It's a crazy cycle. The problem is that fake news is usually designed to be super shocking, so it gets a lot of engagement and spreads like wildfire.

10. What do you think is the biggest problem caused by misinformation online? I think the biggest issue is that people just don't know what to trust anymore. Fake news puts everyone in their own little bubbles where actual facts don't seem to matter. It makes it impossible for us to actually talk and solve real-world problems because we can't even agree on what the basic facts are.

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